> "DULLY, I HAULED MYSELF OUT OF THE MUD AND GAVE THE SIGNAL TO ADVANCE, WHICH WAS ANSWERED BY EVERY MAN RISING AND STEPPING UNHESITATINGLY INTO THE BARRAGE."
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> **LIEUTENANT EDWIN CAMPION VAUGHAN**, AT THE THIRD BATTLE OF YPRES, 1917

Since 5.7 million British soldiers served in the conflict, it was clearly not fear of the firing squad that kept them at their posts or drove them loyally to follow their officers "over the top" when an attack was ordered.

OVER THE TOP

Some infantrymen never experienced a major offensive and most only participated once or twice in full-scale operations. It was possible to spend years in the trenches without going "over the top" at all. But when an offensive did happen, it was certainly an experience that no surviving participant ever forgot. At the start of the battle of the Somme, on 1 July 1916, inexperienced soldiers marched forward with full packs straight into machine-gun fire and uncut German wire, and 58,000 men were killed or wounded in a day. But such futile butchery was exceptional. Usually a soldier had a sense of taking part in a fierce battle, rather than being herded to slaughter. Carrying a rifle, essential rations, and digging tools, plus possibly grenades, he would move into position before dawn. The first wave would advance across no man's land as close as possible behind a creeping artillery barrage, hopefully finding the enemy wire cut by shelling or by a preparatory infantry raid. Fighting might be joined at close range, with difficult assaults on concrete machine-gun posts and the clearing of German front-line trenches with grenade and bayonet. It would usually fall to supporting troops to pass through a captured trench and advance against the next line of enemy defences. Attacks became increasingly difficult to sustain as they stretched further from the starting point. As enemy artillery fire rained down on soldiers who had fought their way forward to exposed positions and German infantry mounted counterattacks, the advance would come to a halt or be forced back.

The awesome casualties suffered were a function of the vast destructive power of mass-produced artillery shells and machine-guns, but also of the sheer duration of battles fought with utter tenacity on both sides. The Somme offensive, begun at the start of July 1916, continued until mid-November; the offensive at Ypres the following year, infamous for the appalling mud

Field telephone
Communication between the artillery and the infantry was crucial to the success of an offensive. In the absence of radios, the infantry had to rely on the portable field telephone.



Joining an offensive
British infantrymen thread their way along a sap – a narrow trench extending forward from the front line – and then out through the barbed wire before advancing across no man's land.